# Child Sacrifice at Carthage—Religious Rite or Population Control?

## Archaeological evidence provides basis for a new analysis

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Sidebar: Model of the Tophet



*ASOR Punic Project/Gary Pratico*

**The Tophet, the sacred precinct of Carthage. Here, from the eighth century B.C. until the second century B.C., mothers and fathers of Carthage buried the bones of their children sacrificed to the god Ba'al Hammon and to the goddess Tanit. By the fourth century B.C. the Tophet may have been as large as 64,800 square feet (6,000 square meters), with nine levels of burials. Archaeologists today group these levels into three periods designated Tanit I, II and III.**

**In the foreground, grass grows around sandstone and limestone burial monuments dating from 600 B.C. to 300 B.C. (Tanit II) that were left in place by the Kelsey excavations of 1925. In the background, a member of the ASOR excavation team works to uncover Tanit II levels buried under debris from later Roman and Byzantine occupations. The authors and their team eventually excavated this entire area of the Tophet.**

"Tophet" is a Biblical word. It is the name of a place that was on the south side of ancient Jerusalem in the Valley of Ben-Hinnom, where the Israelites sacrificed their children by fire. It may even refer to the altar on which the sacrifices took place. The book of the prophet Jeremiah describes it:

"'The people of Judah have done evil in my sight,' saith the Lord … 'They built the high place[a] of Tophet, which is in the Valley of Ben-Hinnom, to burn their sons and their daughters in fire. Such a thing I never commanded, nor had in mind'" (Jeremiah 7:30–32).

The Biblical references associate the Tophet with idolatrous worship of Baal:

"They rejected the commandments of the Lord … and served Baal. They consigned their sons and daughters to the fire" (2 Kings 17:16–17; see also Jeremiah 32:35).

The Tophet is also mentioned in connection with the non-Israelite god Molech—or at least that is the assumption of most modern translators (2 Kings 23:10 and Jeremiah 32:35). (Later in this article we shall question that

assumption.) The Jerusalem Tophet was dismantled by King Josiah in the seventh century B.C.:

"[King Josiah of Judah] defiled Tophet, which is in the Valley of Ben-Hinnom, so that no one might consign his son or daughter to the fire of Molech" (2 Kings 23:10).

Whether this was its first destruction and whether it was thereafter rebuilt, we cannot be sure.

These Biblical references have led modern scholars to call by the name Tophet the huge cemetery of sacrificed children at Phoenician Carthage, as well as similar precincts at other Phoenician sites in Sicily, Sardinia and Tunisia.




**Map showing location of Carthage.**

The Carthaginian Tophet is the largest of these Phoenician sites and indeed is the largest cemetery of sacrificed humans ever discovered. Child sacrifice took place there almost continuously for a period of nearly 600 years.

Although the exact boundaries of the cemetery are unknown because modern villas have been constructed over part of the ancient site, we nevertheless estimate the size of the Carthaginian Tophet during the fourth and probably the third centuries B.C. to be, at the minimum, between 54,000 and 64,000 square feet. Using the density of urns in our excavated area as a standard, we estimate that as many as 20,000 urns may have been deposited there between 400 and 200 B.C. Clearly the deposits were not a casual or sporadic occurrence.

The discovery of a Tophet in Carthage came as no surprise. Indeed, Phoenicians in general and Carthaginians in particular were infamous for their child sacrifices. Phoenician child sacrifice is referred to often in ancient literature. For example, the Greek author Kleitarchos, of the third century B.C., was paraphrased by a later writer as saying:

"Out of reverence for Kronos [the Greek equivalent of Ba'al Hammon[b]], the Phoenicians, and especially the Carthaginians, whenever they seek to obtain some great favor, vow one of their children, burning it as a sacrifice to the deity, if they are especially eager to gain success. There stands in their midst a bronze statue of Kronos, its hands extended over a bronze brazier, the flames of which engulf the child. When the flames fall upon the body, the limbs contract and the open mouth seems almost to be laughing, until the contracted [body] slips quietly into the brazier. Thus it is that the 'grin' is known as 'sardonic[c] laughter,' since they die laughing."[1]

Tertullian (c. 160–c. 225 A.D.), a Church Father who lived most of his life in Carthage, writes:

"In Africa infants used to be sacrificed to Saturn, and quite openly, down to the proconsulate of Tiberius, who took the priests themselves and on the very trees of their temple, under whose shadow their crimes had been committed, hung them alive like votive offerings on crosses; and the soldiers of my own country are witnesses to it, who served that proconsul in that very task. Yes, and to this day that holy crime persists in secret. … Saturn did not spare his own children; so, where other people's were concerned, he naturally persisted in not sparing them; and their own parents offered them to him, were glad to respond, and fondled their children that they might not be sacrificed in tears. And between murder and sacrifice by parents—oh! the difference is great!"[2]

The Tophet at Carthage was discovered in December of 1921 when P. Gielly, a public official with an interest in antiquities, observed a local trafficker in antiquities down on his hands and knees, removing stelae by moonlight. Gielly reported the incident to Francois Icard, the chief of police of Tunis. Icard, with Gielly, then purchased the property, and the two of them began excavating the site with funds and archaeological expertise provided both by Louis Poinssot, the director of the Service des Antiquités, and by Raymond Lantier, an inspector with the Service.

They were also assisted by Count Byron Khun de Prorok, who later purchased the property from Gielly and Icard.

In 1924 Count de Prorok teamed up with Abbé Chabot, a distinguished Semitics epigraphist, for further excavations. Count de Prorok, a dilettante archaeologist and raconteur, wrote of his experiences at the excavation:

"This is a dreadful period of human degeneracy that we are now unearthing in the famous Temple of Tanit [that is, the open-air precinct], but such is archaeology! In one spot we may be uncovering works of priceless art and traces of the advancement of civilization, and in another spot the contrasting decadence shown in the revelation of such a cult as found at Aphrodisium and at Carthage in Africa.[3]



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**A seventh century B.C. burial urn (Tanit I) in its pit with lid in place (left) and with lid removed (right), showing the charred remains of an infant.**

In 1925, at the behest of Count de Prorok, a joint French-American expedition directed by Francis W. Kelsey of the University of Michigan continued the work. Kelsey was assisted by a young classicist named Donald B. Harden, whose pioneering study of the urns from this excavation established a pottery typology and chronology that still remain generally valid. In 1962, Harden published a superb archaeological and historical survey of the people who created the Tophet. It is called simply *The Phoenicians*. Revised first in 1971, *The Phoenicians* was again revised and expanded in 1980 for a Pelican Penguin paperback edition.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Dr. Francis Kelsey's excavations of the Tophet in 1925. Kelsey and his team from the University of Michigan, in cooperation with a French team, excavated hundreds of burial urns and monuments, buried layer upon layer in the earth. In one area they reached bedrock and the Tanit I level.**

**Hundreds more urns remained undisturbed, but the expansion of the modern city of Carthage threatened the Tophet as well as other remains of ancient Carthage, and an emergency excavation was begun in the 1970s.**

The excavations, postponed in 1926, were never continued after Kelsey's death in 1927. Some years later, Louis Carton purchased the property adjacent to the previously excavated portion of the Tophet with the intention of exploring it. He died before he could begin excavating, but at the urging of Carton's widow, G. G. Lapeyre of the White Fathers Mission dug there in 1934–1936. In the mid-1940s, Pierre Cintas, the modern doyen of Punic[d] archaeology, directed another round of excavations.

In all, thousands of burial urns and monuments have been excavated in the Tophet, but, sad to say, very few have been published as cultural assemblages in archaeological context. The problem has not been lack of digging but a failure to publish fully and systematically.

In recent years, the modern city of Tunis has been expanding at a rapid pace toward the ruins of ancient Carthage. In the mid- to late-1970s, UNESCO led an international effort to save the ancient city and to excavate where possible, before it was too late. With the cooperation of the Tunisian authorities, scholars from 12 different countries, including Tunisia itself, the United States, Great Britain, France, Germany, Sweden, Holland, Denmark, Italy and Canada, undertook various archaeological projects at the site.[4] Eastern European archaeologists were also involved. Polish archaeologists surveyed the buried walls of the circus using modern resistivity techniques that do not require digging. A Bulgarian team explored the Byzantine basilica of Damous el-Karita. The Americans fielded two teams—one from the University of Michigan and the other from the University of Chicago's Oriental Institute. The Chicago team, led by the senior author of this article, undertook to reexamine and reexcavate the Tophet. We also excavated and surveyed aspects of the ancient commercial harbor. Although the contours of the harbor were roughly preserved for almost two millennia, this identification of the harbor was unconfirmed until our excavations.




**The plan shows that Phoenician Carthage had two large harbors adjacent to the Tophet. The harbors were connected by a waterway and had a common southern entrance from the sea. The southern harbor was used for merchant ships and the northern circular harbor for military vessels.**

**The Roman historian Appian, following the eyewitness account of the Greek historian Polybius who was present at the Roman siege and destruction of Carthage in 146 B.C., described in detail these commercial and naval ports that had made such a lasting imprint on the metropolitan landscape and on Roman memory:**

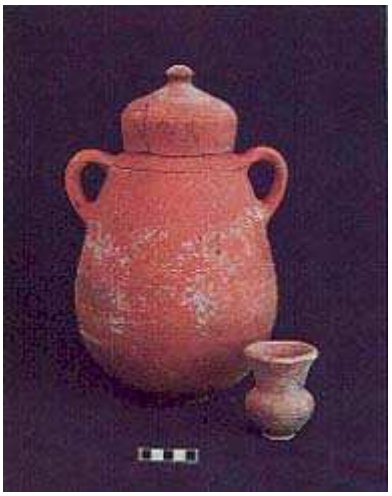
**"The harbors had communication with each other, and a common entrance from the sea 70 feet wide, which could be closed with iron chains. The first port was for merchant vessels, and here were collected all kinds of ships' tackles. Within the second port was an island which, together with the port itself, was enclosed by high embankments. These embankments were full of shipyards which had capacity for 220 vessels … On the island was built the admiral's house, from which the trumpeter gave signals, the herald delivered orders, and the admiral himself overlooked everything."**

**But today, as the aerial photograph (inset) of modern Carthage shows, only two small stagnant lagoons remain from these once great ports. The authors' recent excavations in the commercial harbor and British excavations in the military harbor have dramatically confirmed Appian's account. As reflected in Punic Carthage, the Phoenicians' reputation as a major maritime power, both commercial and military, was well-founded.**

**It is ironic that, during the years when these beautiful harbors were being constructed and Carthage's commercial and political domains were expanding widely in the fourth and third centuries B.C., the number of children sacrificed in the Tophet reached its peak.**

As a result of our work in the Tophet, we have learned a great deal about child sacrifice as well as about this Tophet. Some long-held notions about child sacrifice by ancient authors and by modern scholars, which we once shared, will now have to be discarded.

The ancient Carthaginian Tophet today is in a lovely archaeological park in the modern suburb of Tunis called, once again, Carthage. Beneath the surface, in the trench we excavated, lay nine stratified levels of Tophet burials. These can be fit into the three larger general "strata" (actually "periods"), already established by the Kelsey team and designated Tanit I, II and III. (Tanit was the leading goddess of Carthage and is identified with the eastern Mediterranean goddess Astarte.) We now date Tanit I from about 750/725 to 600 B.C.; Tanit II from about 600 B.C. to the third century B.C.; and Tanit III from the third century B.C. to 146 B.C. Tanit I had four separate stratigraphic phases, as did Tanit II. Tanit III was so badly disturbed by the Romans that no distinction among its various levels of burial could be discerned.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Burial urn from the seventh century B.C. (Tanit I). This undecorated urn contained a small votive vase along with the cremated remains of a child.**

In 146 B.C. the Romans destroyed and leveled much of the city, fulfilling the oft-reiterated exhortation of Cato the

Elder: “Carthage must be destroyed”—”delenda est Carthago.” The Romans put a stop to child sacrifice at Carthage, but it lingered on in other parts of North Africa. As a result of this destruction of Carthage, almost nothing from the Tanit III level was left *in situ*. The Romans uprooted hundreds of stelae from the uppermost Tanit III period and reused them in construction fills and in walls at the circular harbor and at other sites at Carthage. In the fourth century A.D. they sunk the foundation arches of warehouses into the earlier strata of the Tophet.

The Tophet burials at Carthage do not date as early as the traditional date for the founding of the city. According to the classical author Timaeus, Carthage was founded in 814 B.C. by a Phoenician princess known as Dido to the North Africans but called Elissa in Phoenician. Dido was the sister of Pygmalion (*Pummayaton* in Phoenician), king of Tyre. When Pygmalion murdered his brother-in-law, Dido’s husband, Dido fled from Phoenicia. First she and the nobles who fled with her landed in Cyprus. There they picked up the High Priest of Astarte. (Astarte is identified at Carthage with Tanit.) In Cyprus, they also kidnapped some temple virgins for the men. Thus augmented, the expedition left Cyprus and ultimately landed in Carthage—which means “new city” in Phoenician.

Dido bargained with the local ruler for some land on which to build a city. The deal they struck was that the Phoenicians would be allowed to settle on as much land as an oxhide could cover. Clever Dido cut an oxhide into the narrowest possible strips, placed the strips end to end, and surrounded the area that was soon to become a major Phoenician city. From a fledgling colony in the ninth or eighth century B.C., it would develop, in the fourth and third centuries B.C., into the center of Punic power in the Mediterranean.

The Phoenicians, of Canaanite ancestry, had earlier (around 1200 B.C.) acquired territory in what is now coastal Lebanon, Syria and Northern Israel. They were famous as merchant traders, sailors and craftsmen. From the Phoenicians, the Greeks borrowed the Semitic alphabet. In the tenth century B.C. Hiram of Tyre provided King Solomon with masons and architects to help build his Jerusalem Temple and ships and crews to service his Ophir and Tarshish expeditions (1 Kings 5:1ff.; 1 Kings 7:13–45; 1 Kings 10:11, 22).

How the Phoenicians actually got to Carthage is difficult to tell because the account of Timaeus is clearly a mixture of legend and history. Although all the details of his account may not be entirely accurate, 814 B.C. does seem a reasonable date for the founding of Carthage.

The earliest archaeological evidence for the occupation of Carthage goes back to about 750 B.C. The first settlement was probably on a hill called Byrsa—located about 1200 yards north of the Tophet. Byrsa has an interesting etymology. It is a Greek word which means “oxhide”—remember how Dido got title to Carthage. The Greeks who named the hill were probably making a pun on the Semitic word *brt* which means “fortress” or “citadel.” The earliest Phoenicians may have built a fortress or citadel, called *brt*, on this hill.

Later Phoenician occupation and then the leveling activities of the conquering Romans obliterated the earliest remains on the Byrsa.

The Tophet at Carthage, like other Phoenician Tophets, is located in a special open-air precinct (often called the Precinct of Tanit) enclosed by a thick wall which sets it apart from other areas of the city. Although the wall itself was robbed out in antiquity, we found the trench dug into bedrock, in which the foundation stones of the wall were laid; the trench is over six feet wide.

The Tophet was literally filled with burial urns and burial monuments. Our own excavation uncovered over 400 urns containing charred young human or animal bones and ashes. Each urn was placed in a pit which was sometimes lined with cobbles and capped with a flat stone. Sometimes there were two or three urns in one pit. Some of the urns contained offerings of amulets and beads once strung as necklaces.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Burial urn from the seventh century B.C. (Tanit I). The tulip shape of this urn is very similar to the shape of a small votive vase that was found inside the undecorated urn with the cremated remains of a child (see photograph).**

Urns from the earliest levels (Tanit I) were frequently decorated with wide red-slipped[e] and burnished[f] bands at the waist and vertical line patterns at the shoulder. These Tanit I urns were sealed with unbaked red clay stoppers (probably the same clay used to make the urn) and capped with a bowl or lid. They rested on bedrock in a matrix of black clay.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Burial urn from the seventh century B.C. (Tanit I). Only between eight and twelve inches high, pottery urns from the Tophet's earliest phase were often decorated with red bands and vertical lines.**



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**Burial urn from the seventh century B.C. (Tanit I). Only between eight and twelve inches high, pottery urns from the Tophet's earliest phase were often decorated with red bands and vertical lines.**

In the middle period (Tanit II) the clay of the urn and stopper was usually yellow. The most common urn shape was "wasp-waisted." The urns from Tanit III were mass produced—they were all of a smaller standardized form and were undecorated. The clay of the Tanit III urns was light buff or white.

Each burial monument was placed directly above the urn to mark the burial of the sacrifice, although not every urn had a marker.

As with the urns, the style of the burial monuments changed from period to period. Most frequent in the Tanit I levels were L-shaped monuments of sandstone called cippi (singular *cippus*). The sandstone for the cippi came from nearby Cap Bon.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**L-shaped sandstone monument from the Tanit I level, seventh century B.C. The burial urn beneath this monument contained only charred lamb bones. At this early date Carthage was a newly established town with a small population. The sacrifice of an animal as a substitution for a child was more frequent than in later periods, probably because population growth was considered desirable in the fledgling colony. But later, as Carthage flourished and grew to enormous size, a vow to the gods was more likely to be fulfilled with a child, rather than with an animal substitute.**

In Tanit II the cippi were larger and bore elaborate carved motifs on the front. A frequent motif was a cult symbol representing a female deity—carved naturalistically in the shape of a human female figure, set within the sacred portal of a temple facade. Stucco[9] once covered these sandstone monuments but is, for the most part, unpreserved. From small preserved patches, however, we can tell that the stucco was once painted in bright colors.



*ASOR Punic Project/Samuel Wolff*

**Sandstone monument. Patches of stucco still adhere to this burial marker erected more than 2,500 years ago. Carved out of one piece of sandstone, this monument from the Tanit II level is much larger and better worked than the earlier Tanit I L-shaped monuments.**

Later in the Tanit II period, limestone stelae[h] rather than sandstone cippi were used as monuments. These Tanit II stelae often have a gable at the top. Carved on the front are inscriptions and symbols, for example, upraised hands symbolizing Tanit and a disk and crescent probably symbolizing Ba'al Hammon. The inscriptions are written in Punic, which is a variant of Phoenician. In the Tanit III period, the limestone stelae become thinner and the gable is usually flanked by two wings or acroteria. These Tanit II stelae inscriptions include the first appearance of the actual name of the goddess Tanit. Ba'al Hammon is attested as early as the seventh century B.C.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Tall and imposing, this Tanit II limestone monument stands in striking contrast to the very small pottery urn it memorializes beneath. The incised Punic inscription on the stela names the dedicant as Eshmun-hilles. Excavators removed this fourth century B.C. urn and found that it contained the cremated remains of a newborn child.**

At Hazor in northern Israel, an amazing discovery paralleling these symbols on the Carthaginian stelae was made. At the center of a group of stelae (*masseboth* in Hebrew) in a small sanctuary, a 1¾-foot-high *massebah* was found carved with a relief of upraised hands and a disk and crescent. Although the Hazor sanctuary predates the Tophet by a thousand years, Yigael Yadin, excavator of Hazor, believes that the hands and the disk and crescent symbolize the same deities—Tanit and Ba'al Hammon. Yadin concludes that "it is quite clear that the Punic culture preserved elements of the Phoenician culture, and the latter was definitely influenced by Canaanite elements, similar to the ones uncovered in Hazor."

Several scholars have been skeptical about interpreting the Tophet remains as evidence of Carthaginian child sacrifice. The famous archaeologist Claude Schaeffer[i] who excavated Ugarit, and more recently Hélène Benichou-Safar, who has restudied the various necropoleis of Carthage,[5] concluded that the children buried in the Tophet had not been the victims of ritual sacrifice but had died of natural causes. The distinguished Biblical scholar Moshe Weinfeld cites Schaeffer with approval, as he attempts to reduce child sacrifice to a "sporadic, non-institutionalized" phenomenon at Carthage and to eliminate it altogether from the Bible as just so much prophetic-poetic hyperbole, with no resemblance to the realities of "Molech worship."[6]

Even if we dismiss the classical literary evidence for child sacrifice as ancient slanders spread by foreign antagonists who wanted to discredit the Carthaginians, the growing body of archaeological and epigraphic evidence, provided by the Carthaginians themselves, strongly suggests that the classical and Biblical writers knew

what they were talking about.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Contents of the urns had to be carefully removed. All the urns excavated in the Tophet contained fragile burned bones. The archaeologists had to develop an effective system for extracting urn contents without damaging the delicate remains. Here excavators gently use water from a garden hose to loosen the contents of an urn so that they can be emptied onto a mesh screen. Dirt and ash sift through the screen, leaving the bone and other residues to dry. The remains of two other urns are drying on this screen. Once the contents dry, the bones are sorted and analyzed by osteologists.**

This evidence includes inscriptions on the stelae. Some of these inscriptions mention a vow made to the deities by the offerants, something that is never inscribed on ordinary funerary stelae. And then there are the offerings themselves, buried beneath the monuments, with the charred remains of children or animals. In some periods, especially Tanit II, we find double or even triple children's burials in the same urn, presumably offered from a single family. Usually a stillborn or newborn (neonate) is included with a two- to four-year-old child. It seems unlikely that disease or some other disaster would have affected only the two youngest children (that is, the stillborn/newborn and the two- to four-year-old) from the same family in such a regular fashion.

But probably the clearest evidence that this is no ordinary children's cemetery (which in itself is extremely rare in the ancient world) is the presence of animal burials, mostly young sheep and goats (their bones always charred), which are found in their own individual urns, interspersed with burial urns containing human infants, throughout the precinct. Should we conclude that the Tophet was also a "pet cemetery," with cremated lambs and kids?

In one seventh-century B.C. urn we found only the bones of a charred male lamb buried beneath an L-shaped sandstone monument placed above the urn. In addition, sheep are depicted on some stelae from the fourth to second centuries B.C.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**A sheep, carved into the upper register of a Tanit III limestone stela. In the seventh century B.C., one out of every three burial urns contained animal remains, but by the fourth century (and later) only one out of every ten urns contained only animal remains. The presence of urns that contained only animal bones and that were marked by stone monuments is clear evidence that the Tophet precinct was not an ordinary cemetery but a burial place of sacrifices to the gods.**

It seems rather clear that the burned animals were intended as substitute sacrifices for children. This is confirmed by evidence from Phoenician Tophets at other sites. Punic inscriptions on monuments from Malta, Carthage, and Constantine refer to a *mlk 'mr*. As we shall see later, *mlk* refers to a live sacrifice of a child or animal. The second word, *'mr*, means lamb and indicates that the sacrifice was an animal rather than a human.

Second- and third-century A.D. Latin inscriptions on stelae from Algeria are also revealing. There we find the Phoenician *mlk 'mr* phrase transcribed in Latin letters as *molchomor*. These are clearly animal substitution sacrifices, as the following recurring Latin phrases on the same stelae affirm: *vita pro vita*; *sanguine pro sanguine*; *agnum pro vikario* which means "Life for life, blood for blood, a lamb as a substitute."

There can thus be little doubt that the burnt animal burials at Carthage are animal substitutes for child sacrifices and that this site is not simply a children's cemetery, but is in fact a precinct of child sacrifice.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**A tiny burial urn is carefully excavated by a member of the University of Chicago's excavation team. The sandstone monument bears no inscription that might identify the infant buried here.**

But why would the Phoenicians resort to such a barbaric practice as human sacrifice, especially of helpless

infants? The Phoenicians were among the most highly civilized and cosmopolitan people in the Mediterranean.

Both the Hebrew Bible and Homer attest to their skills as craftsmen, sailors, and merchants. They built magnificent cities. One of them was, of course, Carthage which our own excavations helped to uncover.

One of the most surprising results of our analyses of the contents of the burial urns is that the demand for human infant sacrifice, as opposed to animal sacrifice, seems to increase rather than decrease with the passage of time.

Our physical anthropologist, Dr. Jeffrey Schwartz of the University of Pittsburgh, systematically examined the contents of 130 of the 400 burial urns we excavated.[7] Most of the urns fell into two chronological groups. The early group dates to the seventh century B.C.; the later group to the fourth century B.C. In the early sample nearly one out of every three urns contained the charred remains of an animal, usually a sheep or goat. In the later sample only one out of ten urns contained the remains of a burnt animal alone, also usually a sheep or goat. The lambs and kids, like the children, were very young when killed. When the sex of the animals could be determined, the lambs and kids were males. In the early days of the colony, animal substitution was a far more common response to the rigid demands of the sacrificial system than in the period of Carthage's heyday.

As we have noted, the animal burials probably represent a substitution for a child sacrifice. One is immediately reminded of the paradigm in Genesis 22 of Abraham's offering to sacrifice Isaac, with the ram in the thicket ultimately sacrificed in his stead. Some cultural anthropologists and historians of religion have seen a "line of development which led from human sacrifice to animal sacrifice to the wafer and the wine of the Eucharist," and in this development they find "a vindication of the moral doctrine of moral progress and enlightenment."[8] According to this cultural evolutionary theory, the "barbaric" practice of human sacrifice was gradually replaced by the more "civilized" practice of animal substitution. Our evidence from Carthage is to the contrary, however. Precisely in the fourth and third centuries B.C., when Carthage had attained the height of urbanity, child sacrifice flourished as never before.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Layer upon layer of urns containing the cremated remains of children fill the huge Tophet in ancient Carthage. In the foreground, emerging from dark brown marsh clay, is a sealed red urn from the earliest phase of burials, Tanit I (750–600 B.C.). The remaining urns belong to the latter part of the middle phase, Tanit II (400–300 B.C.). The density of urns per meter is clearly much greater in the fourth century than in the earlier level. Child sacrifice did not decline then but in fact became more frequent.**

**In the upper left quarter of the photo are two holes dug by ancient Carthaginians, who then lowered the urns containing the bones and ashes of their children into the ground. The pits were**

**often lined with stones and the urn burial then capped with stones; a monument like the one at right was then placed on top. Excavators have removed the monuments and cleared the burial pits. The large weathered sandstone monument (top right) shows Tanit holding a tambourine and standing in the sacred portal of a temple.**

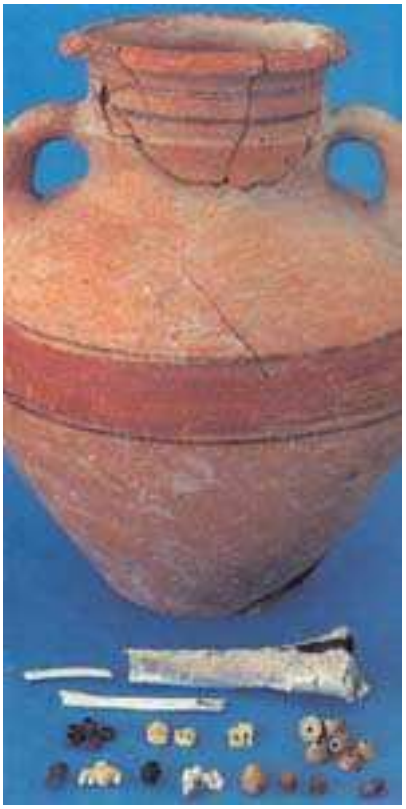
Perhaps in the early days, when Carthage was a fledgling city with few people, animal substitution was widely practiced as an acceptable response to the imperative for Tophet sacrifices. Later, when Carthage was flourishing along the shores of the Gulf of Tunis and the population of the metropolitan area probably exceeded a quarter of a million (Strabo[9] says 700,000), the demographic situation created little pressure for animal substitution. Indeed, it encouraged child sacrifice. Then, children, not animals, were by far the most common sacrificial victims in the Tophet rites.

Some ancient writers have suggested that during times of civic crisis, mass child sacrifice was practiced to appease the gods and ward off calamity. For example, in the late fourth century B.C., the king of Syracuse landed near Carthage at Cap Bon with a large invasionary force. A political crisis ensued, and in 308 B.C. there was an attempted coup at Carthage. The classical Greek historian Diodorus Siculus tells us that during this crisis as many as 500 children were sacrificed in Carthage:

“In their zeal to make amends for their omission to sacrifice the noblest children, they selected two hundred of the noblest children and sacrificed them publicly; and others who were under suspicion sacrificed themselves voluntarily, in a number not less than three hundred. There was in their city a bronze image of Cronus, extending its hands, palms up and sloping toward the ground, so that each of the children when placed thereupon rolled down and fell into a sort of gaping pit filled with fire.”[10]

Our evidence indicates, however, that child sacrifice in times of civic crisis was the exception rather than the rule. We have found no evidence for mass burials. Throughout the nine levels of Tophet burials, dating from about 750 B.C. to 146 B.C., the typical burial pattern involved the careful placement of usually one, sometimes two, and rarely three urns in a single pit.

Infant corpses are composed of a high percentage of cartilage which is destroyed during cremation. Only the hardened bones survive, such as the cranium and the long bones. Teeth are the most heat-resistant, and the stage of dental development provides the most important criterion for determining the approximate age of the victim. The sex of such young individuals cannot be determined from the osteological remains. The skeletal evidence that has been preserved, however, indicates that a conscious effort was made by parents and/or priests to collect from the pyre or altar the particular remains of one or sometimes two individuals and to deposit them in an urn. The absence of the mixing of bones on the pyres, which would have occurred in a mass sacrifice, further indicates that mass sacrifice, if it occurred at all, was rare.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**The dramatic contents of a Tophet burial urn from Tanit II. With a child's bones and teeth, darkened by flames, are amulets and beads also offered to the gods. In the front row, from left to right are: a silver spacer bead, an Egyptian amulet in the form of a sow, a silver double-axe spacer bead, three of the child's teeth, two beads of Baltic amber, one carnelian bead, and a silver spacer bead. In the second row, from left to right are: a cluster of silver beads, two Egyptian domino amulets, an Egyptian udjat or "Eye of Horus" amulet, and a cluster of conical bone beads. The beads may have once been strung on a necklace.**

Inscriptions from the Tophet demonstrate that the commonest reason for child sacrifice was the fulfillment of a vow. The Phoenician/Punic word for vow (*ndr*) frequently appears on inscribed stelae. Taking vows was an old and hallowed Near Eastern custom. As one scholar has described it, "When seeking a certain boon from the deity, the worshipper would promise that upon the granting of this boon he would 'repay' his vow by offering a sacrifice, erecting a stele, or some such appropriate act of thanksgiving."[11]

The fulfillment of sacrificial vows is described in Psalms 66:13–15:

"I will come into thy house with burnt offerings;
I will pay thee my vows,
that which my lips uttered
and my mouth promised when I was in trouble.
I will offer to thee burnt offerings of fatlings,
with the smoke of the sacrifice of rams;
I will make an offering of bulls and goats. *Selah*."

At the Carthaginian Tophet, there are numerous examples of votive inscriptions. This one is typical:

"To our lady, to Tanit, the face of Ba'al
and to our lord, to Ba'al Hammon

that which was vowed (by)
PN son of PN, son of PN
Because he [the deity] heard his [the dedicant's] voice and blessed him."



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Limestone stela from the Tanit III period, 300–146 B.C. The Punic inscription tells us that Bod'ashtart, son of Hanno, has dedicated his child to the goddess Tanit. A pointed gable atop the stela is decorated with a disk and crescent, possibly a symbol for Ba'al Hammon, the consort of Tanit. Two other common Punic religious symbols are carved into the stela the upraised hand and the "sign of Tanit"—the schematic triangle with head and curved lines that represent upraised arms.**

**Many other Tanit III stelae contained the same motifs in different combinations. ASOR Excavation art historian Shelby Brown suggests that stelae pattern "books" existed—parents could go to the local workshop and select a stela from "floor" models or order a stela to be custom made.**

Tanit was the leading goddess of Carthage; her consort was Ba'al Hammon, who was probably the Phoenician equivalent of the patriarch of the Canaanite pantheon, El. El appears frequently in the Hebrew Bible as a general term for God, including the Israelite deity. Carthaginian stelae bear witness to the benevolence of the deities and commemorate in a public way "the ritual act of the donor's repayment of his vow."[12]



*Courtesy James Pritchard, University Museum, University of Pennsylvania*

**Ivory plaque naming "Tanit Ashtart," found in a small shrine in the industrial quarter of the seventh-century B.C. Phoenician city of Sarepta, eight miles south of Sidon on the Mediterranean coast. Professor James Pritchard of the University of Pennsylvania, who discovered this plaque, only 2 inches long and 1.3 inches wide, thinks that it might once have been attached to a statue. The four line Phoenician inscription reads: "The statue which SLM, son of MP'L, son of 'ZY made for Tanit 'Ashtart." (SLM may have been pronounced "Shillem," and 'ZY may have been pronounced "'Uzzay.")**

**This inscription provides the earliest clear evidence for the cult of Tanit in Phoenicia. With the discovery of this inscription, scholars now know that Tanit was originally a Near Eastern deity who ultimately received her greatest veneration in Carthage, where she was the leading goddess.**

**Other evidence of Tanit's presence in the Levant is the "sign of Tanit" on a glass disk from Sarepta, on a stamped amphora from Akto, and on several terra cotta deity figurines found in the sea of Shaveh-Ziyyon, north of Akko.**

Incidentally, a new inscription found at Sarepta on the coast of Phoenicia makes it clear that already in the seventh century B.C., Tanit was identified with Astarte, the Canaanite and Phoenician goddess of love and war.[13] As Astarte or Tanit, we find her carved into the facade of an early sandstone cippus uncovered by earlier excavators of the Carthaginian Tophet; she stands in the sacred portal, with tambourine in hand. She may also be depicted on other Tophet monuments by the more abstract and schematic "sign of Tanit." Together, Tanit/Astarte and Ba'al Hammon, the divine couple—mother and father—hear the vow and receive the offerings of the dedicants.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Tanit in the sacred portal of her temple, holding a tambourine. This decorative motif appears on many sandstone monuments like this one, which dates to the Tanit II period in the Carthaginian Tophet. By the seventh century B.C., Tanit had become identified with the Canaanite goddess Astarte. Pottery figurines of Astarte holding a tambourine have been found in Palestine dating back to the time of Solomon.**



*ASOR Punic Project/Samuel Wolff*

**"To our lady, to Tanit … and to our lord, to Ba'al Hammon, that which was vowed … " reads the Punic inscription on this Tanit II stela. Above the inscription the ancient Carthaginian monument carver has chiseled the disk and crescent and the triangle topped with extended lines and a circle—symbols of the two deities for whom a vow was fulfilled with the sacrifice of a human life.**



*ASOR Punic Project/Gary Pratico*

**Monument (stela) honoring Tanit. Now placed by a pathway in a flower filled archaeological park in modern Carthage, this stela once marked an urn burial in the Tophet. Chiseled into the limestone is the schematic "sign of Tanit." Above her head is the disk and crescent, which is probably a symbol for her consort, Ba'al Hammon.**

Another surprising conclusion of our research is that child sacrifice at Carthage was largely an upper-class custom, at least until the third century B.C. This conclusion is based principally on the work of our staff epigraphist Dr. Paul Mosca, of the University of British Columbia, who has studied the inscriptions on the stelae.



*ASOR Punic Project/James Whitred*

**Beads and amulets discovered in a fourth-century B.C. burial urn. Near the top center of the photo is a small gold pendant in the form of the symbol of Tanit. Immediately to the right of the pendant is a bead of Baltic amber, roughly tubular in shape. Just below and to the left of the gold pendant is an oval seal depicting the goddess Ma'at, probably a local imitation of an Egyptian scarab. To the left of the seal is a faience Egyptian amulet of a dwarf that some scholars identify as a god named Ptah-Sokar. Above and to the left of the dwarf amulet is a rectangular clay pendant. Four large clay disk beads border the collection on the left and bottom right. At the top of the photo, directly above the seal is a small dark silver bead. The other six round beads are made of glass. The largest object, top right, is a faience Egyptian amulet in the form of a hawk with a ram's head.**

On several of the stelae is the Semitic word *mlk*, which we read *mulk*. *Mulk* is the technical word in Semitic for a live sacrifice in fulfillment of a Tophet vow, just as other Semitic words are used to indicate cereal offerings and other kinds of animal sacrifices. There are three kinds of *mulk* sacrifices, of which two are attested at Carthage.

The first type of *mulk* sacrifice is the **mulk 'immor*[j] (Arabic *'immarun*; Aramaic *'immar*). As we have already seen, this is probably a sacrifice of a lamb or kid as a substitute offering for a child.

The second type of *mulk* sacrifice is denominated *mulk ba'al*. The third, not found at Carthage, is *mulk 'adam*.[k] The best interpretation of these terms is that *mulk ba'al* refers to the sacrifice of a "ba'al," that is, the child of a wealthy mercantile or estate-owning family. *'Adam* refers to an ordinary man or commoner. So the *mulk 'adam* indicates the infant sacrifice of an ordinary Phoenician commoner. These two terms, *ba'al* and *'adam*, may reflect a basic social stratification in Punic society between the upper classes (estate owners and merchants) and lower classes (peasants). And, indeed, the classical writers refer to the young sacrificial victims as "nobles." It thus appears that the elite were quite involved in sacrificing their children in the Tophet rites at Carthage.[14]

Moreover, it seems that the dedicants were the parents of the child or children buried in the urns below the monuments. True, Diodorus mentions the "aberrant" practice of some Carthaginians, who bought the children of the poor or took slave children to offer to the gods as substitutes for their own, but Diodorus cites this as the exception, not the "normal" practice.

The vocations of the dedicants are often recorded on the stelae. In the fourth-century B.C. examples, Mosca has found political and military titles, like *shufet* (a "judge") and *rab* ("magistrate," literally a "great one"; compare the title rabbi), as well as cultic personnel titles such as priest, high priest, and "awakener of the god(s)." In the third and second centuries he finds more ordinary vocations like doctors, teachers, scribes, weavers, embroiderers, goldsmiths, iron casters, craftsmen, master craftsmen, salt-workers, sailors, surveyors, weighers, perfumers and sellers of incense, among many others. Perhaps, as Mosca has observed, this reflects the "democratization of an originally restricted rite" at a late period.[15]



*Bardo Museum, Tunis*

**Priest cradles an infant, apparently in preparation for a sacrifice. This poignant scene was carved into a dark limestone stela in the fourth century B.C. Found in the 1920s, in one of the first excavations at the Tophet, the stela stands about three feet high and is also decorated with three floral designs.**

The dedicants are also proud of their genealogies. Long genealogical pedigrees usually indicate people from noble families and lineages. Those dedicants holding civic or cultic offices take their genealogies back at least as far as their great-grandfathers. In one case the dedicant traces his ancestry back 16 generations. His grandfather was a *rab* and his great-grandfather, a *shufet*. Craftsmen and men of commerce, however, trace their genealogies back only one generation.

Let us return for a moment to the *mulk* sacrifice. This word suggests that passages from Jeremiah and Kings, quoted at the beginning of this article, contain an incorrect translation. In Jeremiah 32:35 and 2 Kings 23:10, most translations tell us that at the Tophet in Jerusalem, the Israelites had been causing their children to pass through, or into, the "fire of Molech," an old Semitic deity. The passage probably means rather that the Israelites had been burning their children as a *mulk* sacrifice. Remember that Semitic languages are written without vowels so that Molech and *mulk* are both written the same way—mlk. In fact, the Hebrew word for king (melech) is also written this way. Only from the context can you tell which of these words is meant.

From the inscriptions at Carthage, we begin to understand what a *mulk* sacrifice is—either a young child or a young animal substitute. *Mulk* seems like a far more appropriate translation of *mlk* in Jeremiah and 2 Kings than Molech, a god who is not otherwise referred to in connection with Israelite child sacrifice. (Indeed, it is the familiar Baal who is associated with child sacrifice in 2 Kings 17:16–17 and earlier in Jeremiah 32:35.)

Some Biblical scholars have suggested that child sacrifice was limited to first-born males and associate this restriction with the law of the first-born.[16]

"Thou shalt give me the first-born of thy sons. Thou shalt do the same for thy livestock, big and small. The first-born shall be left seven days with its mother, and then, on the eighth day, thou shalt hand it over to me" (Exodus

22:28–29).[17]

Our evidence at Carthage undermines this alleged link between the dedication of the first-born and child sacrifice. Although in the early period of our sample (seventh to sixth centuries B.C.), most of the sacrificed children were newborns (or stillborns—the skeletal evidence does not allow us to determine the exact age of such a young victim), in the later period (fourth century B.C.) most of the children were one to three years old. In this "late" sample, one out of three urns with human remains contained two or three children. In the cases of triple interments, the dental morphology indicates that two of the three children were twins (always the stillborn or newborn) and that the older child was two to four years old. The age difference between the newborn and the two- to four-year-old indicates that both were probably from the same family (buried in the same urn under the same monument), since this range is the natural birth interval that can be expected in families not practicing prenatal forms of birth control.

A possible "explanation" for the double interments is suggested in the passage from the Greek writer Kleitarchos already quoted, who tells us that the children were vowed by the parents in order to obtain a great favor from the gods. In fulfillment of a vow for a favor granted, the parent would pledge an unborn child. But if this child was either born dead or died before the time of sacrifice (the premature-newborn individual), this created a problem. To fulfill the vow, the parent was obliged to offer the youngest living offspring (the two- to four-year-old) as an acceptable sacrifice for the favor granted by the gods. During the fourth century B.C. and later, premature and newborn sacrifices may have been of marginal worth. To remove the ambiguity and to insure the efficacy of the sacrifice, parents were willing to offer older offspring.

If this is true, it is clear that child sacrifice was neither limited to the firstborn, nor was the firstborn a special offering.

Thus far we have understood child sacrifice at Carthage from the religious point of view. Certainly the offerants were motivated by religious concerns and the sacrifice was performed in a religious setting.



*Ralph Crane/Bardo Museum*

**Lion-headed Tanit wearing a feather skirt. This terra cotta statue and four others of the Punic**

**goddess were discovered in 1908 in a coastal village southeast of Carthage. All five date to the late first century B.C. Even after the Romans had conquered Carthage and outlawed human sacrifice, remnants of the Punic population who fled the city defiantly held firm to the bloody cult, as this lofty five-foot-tall Tanit demonstrates.**

But from a sociological point of view, child sacrifice may well have served other less obvious functions. The rite of child sacrifice had long-term practical benefits for various strata within urban Carthage. Ritual infanticide, like more "informal," "secular" forms of infanticide, was probably used as a mechanism for regulating population growth.

Recent work in historical demography, where the sources are much more complete, indicates that infanticide has functioned even in comparatively modern times as a method of population control. French social historians such as Jean-Louis Flandrin and Jean-Claude Peyronnet have shown, for example, that infanticide was the principal means of birth control in France before the 18th century. Peyronnet found that the vast majority of abandoned children in his study of Limoges were legitimate. He also found that "the average age of the abandoned child tended to rise during years of high grain prices, suggesting that the tougher times grew, the older were the children of whom parents were willing to disembarrass themselves."[18]

Among the social elite of Punic Carthage the institution of child sacrifice may have assisted in the consolidation and maintenance of family wealth. One hardly needed several children parceling up the patrimony into smaller and smaller pieces. Even where primogeniture was the rule, family claims of one sort or another might easily disperse the wealth too widely.



*Ralph Crane/Carthage Museum*

**Punic gold coin minted at Carthage in the late fourth century B.C. The serene profile on this coin is of the goddess Tanit, to whom thousands of infants and children were sacrificed in ancient Carthage. Exquisitely detailed, Tanit wears a wreath of wheat along with an elaborate pendant necklace and earrings.**

**By the fourth century B.C. Carthage had become a city of wealth and elegance, as this 9.5 gram coin attests. Yet, at the same time, the number of child sacrifices became far greater than it had been in earlier centuries.**

For the artisans and commoners of Carthage, ritual infanticide could provide a hedge against poverty.

For all these participants in this aspect of the cult, then, child sacrifice provided "special favors from the gods."

From a comparative cultural perspective, child sacrifice, or ritual infanticide, is simply a special form of infanticide. The "non-institutionalized" form has appeared in Graeco-Roman society and in the Christian West with more regularity than we usually are comfortable in admitting. Unwanted or abandoned children have been subjected to exposure, drowning, starvation, strangulation, smothering, and poisoning, but the most common and lethal way of disposing of unwanted children has been simply neglect.[19]

Infanticide was often preferable to abortion because birth order and sex selection could be taken into account for economic reasons. Infanticide was also less dangerous to the physical well-being of the mother.[20] What effects it had on her psyche is another matter. This probably varied with the "cultural distance" that was established

between mother and infant.

As early as 787 A.D. the first foundling home was established in Milan, followed by hospitals in Rome, Florence, and other cities. This was the church's answer to a major social problem: infanticide and the abandonment of unwanted children. At the end of the 12th century, Pope Innocent III established the Hospital of the Santo Spirito in Rome "because so many women were throwing their children into the Tiber."[21]

London, Paris and St. Petersburg had well-known children's hospitals. By the mid-1830s, the St. Petersburg hospital had "25,000 children on its rolls and was admitting 5,000 newcomers annually. It was efficient and well-run; nevertheless, 30 to 40 percent of the children died during the first six weeks and hardly a third reached the age of six."[22] In the London hospital, by mid-18th century, it was impossible to cope with the number of unwanted children. In the words of John Brownlow, "Instead of being a protection to the living, the institution became, as it were, a charnel-house for the dead."[23]

To protect parental anonymity, Napoleon had turntables added to French foundling homes in 1811, "so that the mother or her agent could place the child on one side, ring a bell, and have a nurse take the child by turning the table, the mother remaining unseen and unquestioned."[24] It was so effective that the hospitals were swamped with babies, and the turntables had to be removed.

Ritual infanticide at Carthage served some of the same ends as informal infanticide did from antiquity till now in other societies. For the Carthaginians, this religious institution was immensely important. Of course, it had the overt support of the state. We feel discomfort with the ostentation of the Carthaginian cult—its special precinct, the painted urns, the inscribed monuments. It is repulsive, but then so too is the way so many children in our tradition have perished in less obvious ways. Perhaps the Carthaginians would have gotten a better press in the West had they concealed their practices more subtly.

## Model of the Tophet

Sidebar to: Child Sacrifice at Carthage—Religious Rite or Population Control?



**Model of the Tophet.**

When an excavation in Tunisia has been completed, it must, according to law, be made accessible to tourists—paths must be landscaped and markers and explanatory signs prominently posted. But in the case of the Carthaginian Tophet, the huge cemetery of children sacrificed to the gods, this was impossible. A steadily rising water level at the site insured that if left to nature, the Tophet would turn into stagnant, mosquito-infested pools. The American team that excavated the Tophet in the 1970s was obliged to fill it in with dirt at the end of the last season.

But a portion of the Tophet will be preserved—as a life-size replica of one ten-foot-long, five-foot-high cross-section. (The Tophet itself may once have been as large as 64,000 square feet.) This replica will become a permanent exhibit in the Carthage Museum, which is located atop the Byrsa, the legendary original site of the city.

Using the archaeologists' field notebooks, the model builders replicated the color and texture of the Tophet's soil layers and "carved out" burial pits according to the section's recorded stratigraphy. Actual urns and monuments were then placed in the model just as they were discovered. For example, at the far left a small sandstone

cippus from the earliest level of the Tophet (Tanit I) marks a tulip-shaped burial urn beneath.

Completing the exhibit will be photographs and drawings from the excavation with captions in English, French and Arabic to help explain the meaning of the Tophet.

**BAR** readers can help complete this permanent exhibit of the Tophet, which will be opened to the public in Carthage next year. Send your tax deductible contributions to the Oriental Institute, the University of Chicago, Chicago, Illinois 60637; make checks payable to "Carthage Model, Oriental Institute."

## Footnotes:

**a.** The Hebrew word is plural, *bamot*, but only one high place seems to be referred to—the Tophet. The Septuagint (an early Greek translation of the Bible) and many modern translations such as John Bright's Anchor Bible *Jeremiah* (p. 57) render *bamot* in the singular.

**b.** Ba'al Hammon was the patriarch of the Phoenician pantheon and the consort of Tanit. Tanit was the chief Phoenician goddess of Carthage, to whom most of the child sacrifices at Carthage were made. Indeed, the Tophet is referred to as the Precinct of Tanit.

**c.** The word sardonic derives from Sardinia, where a plant grew that was said to cause convulsions that resembled laughter and ended in death.

**d.** Punic refers to the Phoenicians in Carthage and in the Western Mediterranean. The word is derived from the Latin adjective Punicus.

**e.** A slip is a suspension of clay in water applied to the surface of a ceramic vessel before firing in order to improve its color and texture and to render it less permeable.

**f.** Burnishing consists of smoothing the surface of a vessel before firing with a hard tool such as a shell, a stone or a bone to give it luster.

**g.** Stucco is a fine plaster used to decorate otherwise unattractive surfaces.

**h.** *Stela* is the Latin form (plural *stelae*); *stele* is the Greek form (plural *stelai*).

**i.** See "Remembering Ugarit," **BAR** 09:05.

**j.** The asterisk before the *m* in *mulk 'immor* indicates that this is a reconstructed form, a suggestion of how the words were vocalized. The reconstruction *mulk 'immor* can be confidently suggested based on related words in comparative Semitic and Latin texts.

**k.** The *mulk 'adam* is found frequently at Constantine in the second century B.C.

## Endnotes:

**1.** For translation, see P. G. Mosca, *Child Sacrifice in Canaanite and Israelite Religion: A Study in Mulk and Molech*, Ph.D. dissertation, Harvard University, 1975, p. 22.

**2.** *Apology* IX. 2–4, *Apology and De spectaculis*, translated by T. R. Glover in Loeb Classical Library, 1931.

**3.** de Prorok, *Smithsonian Annual*, 1925, p. 571.

**4.** For summaries of the Tophet excavations (1976–79), see L. E. Stager, "Carthage: A View from the Tophet" in *Phönizier im Westen*, ed. by H. G. Niemeyer, *Madrider Beiträge* 8 (1982), pp. 155–166; also "The Rite of Child Sacrifice at Carthage" in *New Light on Ancient Carthage*, ed. by J. G. Pedley (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1980), pp. 1–11. For the commercial and naval harbors, see Henry Hurst and L. E. Stagar, "A Metropolitan Landscape: The Late Punic Port of Carthage," *World Archaeology* 9 (1978), pp. 334–346.

**5.** H. Benichou-Safar, "À propos des ossements humains du tophet de Carthage," *Rivista di Studi Fenici* 9 (1981), pp. 5–9.

**6.** M. Weinfeld, "The Worship of Molech and of the Queen of Heaven and Its Background," *Ugarit-Forschungen* IV (1972), pp. 133–154. For a lively rebuttal, see M. Smith, "On Burning Babies," *Journal of the American Oriental Society* 95 (1975), pp. 477–79, and then Weinfeld's reply, *Ugarit-Forschungen* 10 (1978), pp. 411–16.

**7.** Preliminary examination of the remainder of the urns has not changed the overall trends.

**8.** Marvin Harris, *Cannibals and Kings* (Random House: New York, 1980), p. 119.

**9.** Strabo XVII, 3, 15.

**10.** *Diodorus* XX, 14.4–7, trans. by R. M. Gear, Loeb Classical Library, 1962.

**11.** Carl Graesser, "Standing Stones in Ancient Palestine," *Biblical Archaeologist* 35 (1972), p. 42.

**12.** Ibid., p. 43.

**13.** J. Pritchard, "The Tanit Inscription from Sarepta" in *Phönizier im Westen*, ed. by H. G. Niemeyer, *Madrider Beiträge* 8 (1982), pp. 83–92. See also Pritchard, *Recovering Sarepta, a Phoenician City*, (Princeton Univ. Press, 1978), pp. 104–107.

**14.** P. G. Mosca, *Child Sacrifice in Canaanite and Israelite Religion: A Study in Mulk and Molech*.

**15.** P. G. Mosca, "The Offerants and Their Professions," paper delivered at the Carthage Symposium held at the national conference of the Society for Biblical Literature/American Schools of Oriental Research, San Francisco, 1981.

**16.** Exodus 13:2, Exodus 13:11–15; Exodus 22:28–29; Exodus 34:19–20; Numbers 3:4–51; Numbers 8:17–18; Numbers 18:15–16.

**17.** According to Roland de Vaux, there is no evidence that the Israelites took this imperative literally. While the first-born may have been "dedicated" to Yahweh, they were not necessarily sacrificed to him as the animals were. See R. de Vaux, *Ancient Israel*, McGraw-Hill, New York, 1965, pp. 443–44; P. G. Mosca, *Child Sacrifice in Canaanite and Israelite Religion*, pp. 237–38.

**18.** Edward Shorter, "Infanticide in the Past," review of D. Bakan's *Slaughter of the Innocents: A Study of the Battered Child Phenomenon*, in *History of Childhood Quarterly* I (1973) pp. 178–180; Jean-Claude Peyronnet, "L'Attitude à l'égard du petit enfant et les conduites sexuelles dans la civilisation occidentale, structures anciennes et évolutions," *Annales de démographic historique* (1973), pp. 143–210.

**19.** W. L. Langer, "Infanticide: A Historical Survey," *History of Childhood Quarterly* I (1974), pp. 358–359.

**20.** R. W. Eng and T. C. Smith, "Peasant Families and Population Control in Eighteenth-Century Japan," *Journal of Interdisciplinary History* 6 (1976), pp. 417–445.

**21.** R. C. Trexler, "Infanticide in Florence: New Sources and First Results," *History of Childhood Quarterly* I (1973), p. 99.

**22.** Langer, op. cit.

**23.** Ibid.

**24.** Ibid.

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